

Bicycling on the rise

WHEN THE LEAGUE OF American Bicyclists bestowed its bronze Bicycle Friendly Community award upon Pittsburgh in 2010, it marked a sharp reversal in the city's national reputation as a place for cycling. Two decades earlier, Bicycling magazine had named the city among the 10 worst places for cyclists, largely because it lacked the infrastructure to accommodate them.

That has changed a great deal since 1990. Today, the city and surrounding neighborhoods boast 23 miles of bike trails, with 21 of those miles traveling along the banks of the Allegheny, Ohio and Monongahela rivers. Pittsburgh is now connected to the Great Allegheny Passage, the interstate bike trail that takes riders as far south as Washington, D.C. And bike lanes in the city have steadily increased, as have other amenities, such as public bike racks, including a growing number of racks on Port Authority of Allegheny County buses.

Such progress has even impressed Bicycling magazine, which dropped Pittsburgh from its “worst cities” list and today ranks it as the 28th most bike-friendly city in the nation.

Recent data suggest a growing number of cyclists are using the improved infrastructure. In 2009, an estimated 1.4 percent of Pittsburgh residents relied on biking as their primary mode of travel to and from their jobs, according to U.S. Census Bureau American Community Survey data. That marked a 206 percent increase in bike commuting in the city since 2000—the fourth highest increase among the nation's 60 largest cities.

Moreover, those figures likely underestimate the bike commuting population by excluding more casual bike commuters, says Scott Bricker, executive director of the nonprofit bicycling advocacy organization, Bike Pittsburgh. The group itself has seen significant growth, with the number of its members rising from about 100 to nearly 1,500 in the past five years.

Several factors have contributed to biking's rise in popularity, says Bricker, with improved infrastructure that has made cycling more accessible, safer and enjoyable playing a particularly important role. “The trail system is incredibly important. It's the backbone of what has made bicycling a viable option in Pittsburgh. They hug the rivers. They are relatively flat. They're sort of expressways for bicycles.”

The heightened popularity of biking is part of the rise in the use of alternative modes of transportation by Pittsburgh commuters. An estimated 12.4 percent of Pittsburghers walk to work, according to American Community Survey data. That means cyclists and walkers account for an estimated 13.8 percent of commuters. Only in Boston do more commuters rely on their bikes or their legs to get to work. ■

